

SENATE JOINT RESOLUTION 1084

By Lowe

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Dr. Charles Paul Conn for his distinguished service and many achievements at Lee University.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly take great pleasure in recognizing those educators and leaders who have performed with uncommon devotion and enthusiasm throughout their careers and whose efforts have profoundly shaped institutions of higher learning in this State; and

WHEREAS, one such distinguished individual is Dr. Charles Paul Conn, who has dedicated more than five decades of his professional life to Lee University, shaping its identity and trajectory in ways that have left an indelible mark upon the institution and the broader academic community; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Conn began his tenure at Lee University in 1971 as a psychology instructor and, through the years, served with distinction as department chair, vice president, and full professor before assuming the presidency in 1986, a position he held for thirty-four years, until 2020; and

WHEREAS, following his presidency, he continued to serve the university as chancellor for nearly four years and, in 2024–2025, he once again answered the call to leadership by serving concurrently as president and chancellor; and

WHEREAS, under Dr. Conn's visionary leadership, Lee University experienced extraordinary growth in enrollment, academic offerings, campus development, and national reputation, with enrollment and campus size increasing fivefold, the university's operating budget growing tenfold, and more than thirty major construction projects being completed; and

WHEREAS, he further strengthened the academic mission of the university by launching its first graduate and doctoral programs and introducing hallmark initiatives such as Global

Perspectives and Service Learning, thereby enriching the educational experience of countless students; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Charles Paul Conn's own academic achievements include undergraduate study at Lee College and Georgia State University; graduate study at Emory University, where he earned his master's degree and a Ph.D. in psychology; and postgraduate study at Harvard University's Graduate School of Education, where he studied under numerous distinguished scholars, in addition to serving as a Visiting Scholar at Harvard Divinity School; and

WHEREAS, an accomplished author, Dr. Conn has written more than twenty books, four of which have been recognized as *New York Times* bestsellers, further extending his influence beyond the campus and into the broader cultural and intellectual landscape; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Conn has received numerous honors and distinctions throughout his career, including the M.C. Headrick Award as the outstanding CEO in the Cleveland/Bradley County region and the Otis Floyd Award for excellence in higher education leadership in Tennessee, and he has lent his expertise to a number of prominent organizations, including the Southern Association of Colleges and Schools, the Council for Independent Colleges, and the Council for Christian Colleges and Universities; and

WHEREAS, his many professional accomplishments aside, Dr. Charles Paul Conn is most grateful for the love and support he shares with his wife, Darlia McLuhan Conn, and their family, including their three children and ten grandchildren, many of whom are also alumni of Lee University; and

WHEREAS, Dr. Conn's enduring contributions have helped elevate Lee University to a place of distinction among institutions of higher learning; and

WHEREAS, throughout his remarkable career, Dr. Charles Paul Conn has demonstrated the utmost professionalism, ability, and integrity, winning the unqualified respect and admiration of his colleagues, students, and the citizens of this State; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH
GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE HOUSE OF
REPRESENTATIVES CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Dr. Charles Paul Conn for
his extraordinary service and many achievements at Lee University and extend to him our
sincere appreciation for his invaluable contributions to higher education in Tennessee.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared
for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to
the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear
without House or Senate designation.